THE BATTLE OF HAMPTON ROADS

Faced with overwhelming Union naval superiority and a blockade of its coasts, the Confederacy sought salvation in new technology: ironclad warships. Building upon the half-burned hull of the steam frigate USS *Merrimack*, captured at Gosport in the first days of the Civil War, the Confederates created a ship completely covered down to the waterline in 4in (102mm) thick iron plates. On March 8, 1862, this sinister, ungainly fighting machine, renamed CSS *Virginia*, steamed out from Norfolk Navy Yard to challenge the Union frigates blockading the Hampton Roads.

HISTORIC ENCOUNTER

Although it carried 12 assorted guns (four rifles, two howitzers, and six Dahlgren smoothbores), *Virginia*'s chief weapon was an iron ram, created in response to rumors that the Union, too, had an ironclad—one that might resist *Virginia*'s guns. *Virginia*'s captain, 61-year-old Franklin Buchanan, had orders to effect "prompt and successful action." Without hesitation he set his course directly for the wooden frigate USS *Cumberland*. Steaming inexorably forward, immune to *Cumberland*'s broadsides, *Virginia* smashed its ram into the frigate's hull. As *Cumberland* sank, the ironclad was almost dragged to the bottom, disengaging at the expense of snapping the ram. *Virginia*'s next victim was USS *Congress*. Deliberately run aground to escape ramming, the frigate provided target practice for *Virginia*'s gunners. *Congress* eventually struck its colors but *Virginia*'s acceptance of the surrender was interrupted by fire from Union soldiers on shore. Buchanan himself was shot in the leg—the limb was later amputated. Before handing over command, he angrily ordered his gunners to fire on *Congress* with heated iron shot, setting it aflame.

By the end of the day yet another Union frigate, *Minnesota*, was aground and at *Virginia*'s mercy. The ironclad, now under Lieutenant Catesby ap Roger Jones, retired to rest its crew, intending to finish the job the following day. This it would undoubtedly have done but for the timely arrival (for the Union) of an even stranger vessel. Aware of the Confederates' progress with *Virginia*, the Union had indeed rushed to complete its own revolutionary ironclad. USS *Monitor*, towed south from New York, with no time for sea trials and an inexperienced crew, reached the Hampton Roads on the

US CIVIL WAR



BATTLE OF HAMPTON ROADS

Date	March 8–9, 1862
Location	Off Sewell's Point, Virginia
Result	Inconclusive

COMBATANTS

UNION	CONFEDERACY

COMMANDERS

John L. Worden **Samuel D. Green**	**Franklin Buchanan,** **Catesby ap R. Jones**

FORCES

Ships: 1 ironclad, 5 wooden frigates	**Ships:** 1 ironclad, 2 wooden warships, 1 gunboat

LOSSES

Men: 261 killed, 108 wounded **Ships:** 2 frigates	**Men:** 7 killed, 17 wounded **Ships:** none

> DURING THE ACTION THEY CHEERED AND CHEERED AGAIN. THEIR COOLNESS AND SKILL WERE THE MORE REMARKABLE FROM THE FACT THAT THE GREAT MAJORITY OF THEM WERE UNDER FIRE FOR THE FIRST TIME.
>
> **LIEUTENANT CATESBY AP ROGER JONES,** WRITING OF HIS CREW ABOARD *VIRGINIA*

